SUGAR-FREE SWEETS CAME AS A GODSEND FOR SHANTA BOSE, a 51-year-old homemaker in Gurugram, who was diagnosed as diabetic when she was 47. "Everywhere I went, there were desserts I could not eat," says Bose. Then, she discovered the sugar-free shelf in her local department store, laden with cookies, cakes, candy, soft drinks and ice cream. She also read up on the low glycaemic index (GI)—a scale that ranks foods based on how quickly they raise blood sugar (glucose) levels post ingestion and where foods like fruits, millets, leafy vegetables and beans, which are digested slowly and therefore cause glucose levels to rise gradually, are considered good for diabetics. This prompted Bose to buy brown rice, millets, whole wheat and natural sweeteners like syrups from agave, tapioca, dates, yacon, coconut and monk fruit. For three months, she ended her meals with these, until one day she woke up with blurry vision. Tests showed her blood sugar to be abnormally high. It is a rude shock that greets many in India.

The vilification of sugar as the source of all ill health has seen a surge in demand for sugar-free products, with companies rising to the occasion with gusto. In 2019, a study by market research firm Mintel discovered that almost three in five Indians wish to consume less sugar for a healthier lifestyle, and a 2025 survey found a third of Indian parents seeking less sugar candy for kids. The fears associated with sugar are not unfounded. India is the diabetes capital of the world. A study published in *Lancet* in 2023 found over 100 million Indians to be diabetic and another 136 million as pre-diabetic. Today, sugar is associated with disorders of practically every part of the body: be it the feet or the eyes, the brain or one's bones. "Clamping down on sugar has become a known narrative. Every obese, pre-diabetic, diabetic and non-diabetic/ non-obese person wants sugar-free products," says nutritionist Ishi Khosla.

Following global trends, the Indian food industry is investing heavily in low calorie, low GI products. From mithai, ice cream, jams, sauces, bread, to alternative sweeteners like stevia, erythritol and xylitol, all come in 'sugar-free' avatars. According to market analysis by the IMARC Group, the Indian sugar-free market, comprising sugar-free and diabetic-friendly foods and beverages, was worth Rs 9,586 crore in 2024, and is projected to reach Rs 22,082 crore by 2033. But just as the fat-free health fad of the 1990s, when despite painting fat as the villain, obesity rates continued to soar, the obsession with sugar-free foods can have an unexpected effect, experts warn. "The only things without sugar are air and water," says Dr Jasjeet Wasir, head of endocrinology and diabetology at Medanta Gurugram. "Good health requires balance; you can't focus on one aspect of nutrition."

₹9,586 cr

Size of the Indian sugar-free market in 2024, according to a market analysis by the IMARC Group

SUGAR AND DIABETES

Everything we consume contains some or the other chemical form of sugar (whose structure comprises a molecule each of fructose and glucose), which is broken down into its components in the body. To function normally, humans need glucose. When the intestines extract glucose from food and release it in the blood, it is known as blood sugar. If what one eats is broken down quickly, it spikes blood sugar, which puts pressure on the beta cells of the pancreas that create insulin—the hormone that moves glucose into cells to create life-giving energy. Such pressure eventually results in the cells in the muscles, fats and liver not responding to insulin, with the extra glucose staying in the bloodstream, leading to diabetes.

Hence the pivot to sugar-free products. But just because something is labelled 'sugar free' does not mean it won't be broken down into sugar. "All food gets broken down into blood glucose," says Dr Wasir. A sugar-free cake may lack refined sugar, but the wholewheat flour, eggs, chocolate and butter get converted into lactose and glucose during digestion. That is why experts recommend looking beyond the 'added sugar' figure on a label and check the 'total sugar' and 'calorie' numbers too. Calories represent the energy content in food and consuming more than needed leads to weight gain. "Some sugar-free products can be very caloric, leading to weight gain, which is also a risk factor for diabetes and other diseases," adds Dr Wasir.

Sugar substitutes, and even natural sweeteners like honey, jaggery, dates, monkfruit and agave nectar should be counted as part of our daily glucose intake despite the low calories. "They are better than pure sugar, of course, but it is not a ticket to consuming them in vast quantities," says Khosla. Natural sweeteners may also increase the craving for calorie-dense and sweet foods. As for artificial sugars, the zero GI may seem like a panacea, but they, too, can cause sugar cravings, as a 2010 study in the *Yale Journal of Biology and Medicine* showed. Many sugar alcohols have been linked to cancer. There is also strong medical belief that